

Door Selection Guide

Your Complete Guide to Choosing the Perfect Doors for Your Home

Hero Handyman Pro | St. Louis & Metro East

Introduction

Choosing the right doors for your home is about more than just aesthetics—it's about security, energy efficiency, durability, and functionality. Whether you're replacing an old entry door, upgrading interior doors, or adding a new door to your home, this guide will help you make informed decisions.

From material options and styles to hardware and installation considerations, we'll walk you through everything you need to know to select doors that enhance your home's beauty, comfort, and value.

Section 1: Types of Doors

Entry Doors (Exterior)

Purpose: Main entrance to your home, providing security, insulation, and curb appeal.

Key Considerations:

- Security and durability
- Weather resistance
- Energy efficiency
- Aesthetic impact on home's exterior

Common Materials:

- **Steel:** Most secure and affordable, low maintenance, energy-efficient

- **Fiberglass:** Mimics wood appearance, extremely durable, low maintenance
- **Wood:** Classic beauty, customizable, requires regular maintenance
- **Aluminum/Glass:** Modern look, less secure, best for protected entryways

Interior Doors

Purpose: Separate rooms, provide privacy, enhance interior design.

Common Types:

- **Panel doors:** Traditional style with raised or flat panels
- **Flush doors:** Smooth, flat surface for modern or minimalist homes
- **French doors:** Glass panes for light and openness between rooms
- **Barn doors:** Sliding doors for space-saving and rustic charm
- **Pocket doors:** Slide into wall cavity to save space

Common Materials:

- **Hollow-core:** Lightweight, affordable, suitable for closets
- **Solid-core:** Heavier, better sound insulation, more durable
- **Solid wood:** Premium option, excellent sound dampening

Patio Doors

Purpose: Connect indoor and outdoor living spaces with easy access and natural light.

Common Types:

- **Sliding glass doors:** Space-efficient, wide opening, easy operation
- **French patio doors:** Elegant, full opening, traditional style
- **Bi-fold doors:** Multiple panels that fold, maximum opening

Key Features:

- Energy-efficient glass (Low-E coating)
- Multi-point locking systems
- Durable weather stripping

Storm Doors & Screen Doors

Purpose: Protect entry door, improve ventilation, add security layer.

Benefits:

- Extends life of entry door
 - Allows fresh air while keeping insects out
 - Additional insulation in winter
 - Extra security with reinforced frames
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Section 2: Door Materials Comparison

Material Pros & Cons

Material	Pros	Cons	Best For	Typical Cost
Steel	Secure, affordable, low maintenance, energy-efficient	Can dent, limited styles	Entry doors, security-focused homes	\$\$
Fiberglass	Durable, low maintenance, looks like wood, energy-efficient	More expensive than steel	Entry doors, high-traffic areas	\$\$\$
Wood	Beautiful, customizable, classic appeal	Requires maintenance, can warp/rot	Entry doors, interior doors, traditional homes	
Hollow-Core	Lightweight, very affordable	Not durable, poor sound insulation	Closets, low-traffic interior doors	\$
Solid-Core	Durable, good sound insulation, affordable	Heavier than hollow-core	Bedrooms, bathrooms, home offices	\$\$
Glass	Natural light, modern aesthetic	Less privacy, less insulation	Patio doors, interior French doors	\$—\$\$\$

Section 3: Door Styles & Designs

Entry Door Styles

Traditional:

- Raised panel designs
- Decorative glass inserts

- Classic hardware (brass, bronze)
- Suitable for colonial, craftsman, Victorian homes

Modern/Contemporary:

- Clean lines and minimal ornamentation
- Full-light or sidelights
- Sleek hardware (stainless steel, matte black)
- Suitable for modern, mid-century, minimalist homes

Rustic:

- Wood grain texture
- Wrought iron accents
- Arched or plank designs
- Suitable for farmhouse, cottage, cabin homes

Interior Door Styles

Panel Doors:

- 2-panel, 4-panel, 6-panel configurations
- Raised or flat panels
- Versatile for any home style

Shaker Style:

- Simple, flat panels with clean lines
- Popular in modern and transitional homes

Glass Panel Doors:

- French doors with multiple glass panes
- Single-light doors for offices or dining rooms
- Frosted or textured glass for privacy

Barn Doors:

- Sliding on exposed hardware
 - Space-saving for small rooms
 - Adds character and rustic charm
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Section 4: Hardware & Accessories

Entry Door Hardware

Handlesets:

- **Keyed entry:** Traditional lock and key
- **Smart locks:** Keyless entry with smartphone control
- **Keypad locks:** Code entry, no key needed

Finishes:

- **Polished brass:** Traditional, requires polishing
- **Satin nickel:** Modern, hides fingerprints
- **Oil-rubbed bronze:** Rustic, warm tone
- **Matte black:** Contemporary, bold statement

Additional Features:

- Deadbolts (single or double cylinder)
- Peepholes or door viewers
- Kick plates for durability
- Door knockers

Interior Door Hardware

Knobs vs. Levers:

- **Knobs:** Traditional, compact
- **Levers:** Easier to operate, ADA-compliant

Privacy vs. Passage:

- **Privacy locks:** For bedrooms and bathrooms (can lock from inside)
- **Passage sets:** For hallways and closets (no lock)
- **Dummy knobs:** For closets (non-functional, decorative)

Hinges:

- Standard butt hinges (most common)
 - Ball-bearing hinges (heavy doors, smooth operation)
 - Continuous (piano) hinges (extra support)
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Section 5: Energy Efficiency

Insulation & Energy Ratings

R-Value:

- Measures thermal resistance (higher = better insulation)
- Entry doors: Look for R-5 or higher
- Patio doors: Look for R-3 or higher

Energy Star Certification:

- Indicates door meets energy efficiency standards
- Can reduce heating/cooling costs by 10-15%
- May qualify for tax credits or rebates

Glass Options for Doors

Single-Pane Glass:

- Least expensive
- Poor insulation
- Not recommended for entry or patio doors

Double-Pane (Insulated) Glass:

- Two layers of glass with air or gas between
- Significantly better insulation
- Standard for modern entry and patio doors

Low-E Coating:

- Reflects heat while allowing light through
- Reduces UV damage to furniture
- Improves energy efficiency by 30-50%

Tempered or Laminated Glass:

- Safety glass that doesn't shatter into sharp pieces
 - Required by code for patio doors and large glass panels
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Section 6: Door Sizing & Fit

Standard Door Sizes

Entry Doors:

- Width: 36" (standard), 32" or 42" (less common)
- Height: 80" (standard), 96" (8-foot ceilings)

Interior Doors:

- Width: 24" , 28" , 30" , 32" , 36"
- Height: 80" (standard), 96" (tall ceilings)

Patio Doors:

- Sliding: 5' , 6' , 8' , 12' wide
- French: 5' , 6' wide (pair of doors)

Measuring for a New Door

For Replacement Doors:

1. Measure width at top, middle, and bottom (use smallest measurement)
2. Measure height on left, center, and right (use smallest measurement)
3. Measure door thickness (usually $1\frac{3}{8}$ " or $1\frac{3}{4}$ ")

For New Openings:

- Add 2" to door width for frame (rough opening)
- Add $2\frac{1}{2}$ " to door height for frame and clearance
- Ensure adequate wall space for door swing

Pre-Hung vs. Slab Doors

Pre-Hung Doors:

- Door already mounted in frame with hinges
- Easier and faster to install
- Best for new construction or full replacement
- More expensive but saves labor time

Slab Doors:

- Door only, no frame or hardware
- Requires existing frame in good condition
- More affordable
- Installation requires more skill

Section 7: Installation Considerations

Professional Installation vs. DIY

When to Hire a Professional:

- Entry door replacement (critical for security and weatherproofing)
- Patio door installation (heavy, requires precise leveling)
- New door openings (requires framing, drywall, finishing)
- Structural modifications

DIY-Friendly Projects:

- Replacing interior slab doors (if frame is in good shape)
- Installing new door hardware
- Painting or staining doors
- Installing storm doors

Installation Checklist

Before Installation:

- ☐ Measure opening accurately
- ☐ Order correct door size and style
- ☐ Purchase all necessary hardware
- ☐ Ensure frame is square and level
- ☐ Check for rot or damage in frame

During Installation:

- ☐ Use shims to ensure door is level and plumb
- ☐ Secure frame to studs with appropriate fasteners
- ☐ Install weatherstripping for exterior doors
- ☐ Test door operation (smooth swing, proper latch)
- ☐ Seal gaps with insulation and caulk

After Installation:

- ☐ Install trim and casing
- ☐ Paint or stain as needed
- ☐ Install hardware and locks

- ☐ Test all functions (lock, deadbolt, smooth operation)
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Section 8: Maintenance & Care

Entry Door Maintenance

Every 6 Months:

- Clean door surface with mild soap and water
- Inspect weatherstripping and replace if worn
- Lubricate hinges and locks
- Check for gaps or air leaks

Annually:

- Inspect door for damage (cracks, dents, rot)
- Touch up paint or stain as needed
- Tighten loose hardware
- Check and adjust door closer (if applicable)

Wood Doors:

- Re-stain or re-paint every 2-3 years
- Seal exposed wood to prevent moisture damage
- Sand and refinish if surface becomes worn

Interior Door Maintenance

As Needed:

- Tighten loose hinges or hardware
- Adjust door if it sticks or doesn't latch properly
- Clean with damp cloth (avoid harsh chemicals)
- Touch up paint or finish scratches

Patio Door Maintenance

Monthly:

- Clean door tracks and remove debris
- Wipe down glass with glass cleaner

Every 6 Months:

- Lubricate tracks and rollers
 - Inspect weatherstripping and seals
 - Check locks and adjust if needed
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Section 9: Security Features

Entry Door Security Enhancements

Solid Core or Solid Wood:

- Hollow-core doors are easy to kick in
- Solid doors provide better resistance

Deadbolt Locks:

- Grade 1 deadbolts (highest security)
- 1-inch throw length minimum
- Hardened steel bolt

Reinforced Strike Plates:

- 3-inch screws into door frame studs
- Metal plate distributes force
- Prevents door from being kicked in

Smart Locks & Video Doorbells:

- Remote monitoring and control

- Activity logs and alerts
- Integration with home security systems

Peepholes or Door Viewers:

- Wide-angle view (180 degrees)
- See who’s at the door before opening

Security Hinges:

- Non-removable pins
- Prevents door from being lifted off hinges

Section 10: Cost & Budgeting

Average Door Costs (Materials + Installation)

Door Type	Budget	Mid-Range	High-End
Entry Door (Steel)	500–800	800–1,500	1, 500–3,000
Entry Door (Fiberglass)	800–1,200	1, 200–2,000	2, 000–4,000
Entry Door (Wood)	1, 000–2,000	2, 000–4,000	4, 000–8,000+
Interior Door (Hollow-Core)	150–250	250–400	N/A
Interior Door (Solid-Core)	250–400	400–600	600–1,000
Interior Door (Solid Wood)	400–800	800–1,500	1, 500–3,000+
Sliding Patio Door	800–1,500	1, 500–3,000	3, 000–6,000+
French Patio Door	1, 000–2,000	2, 000–4,000	4, 000–8,000+
Storm Door	200–400	400–600	600–1,000

Prices include materials and professional installation. Costs vary by region, door size, and complexity.

Factors Affecting Cost

- **Door size:** Oversized or custom sizes cost more
 - **Material:** Wood and fiberglass are more expensive than steel
 - **Glass:** Decorative or energy-efficient glass adds cost
 - **Hardware:** Smart locks and premium finishes increase price
 - **Installation complexity:** New openings or structural work add labor costs
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Section 11: Door Selection Worksheet

Your Door Project Details

Project Type:

- ☐ Entry door replacement
- ☐ Interior door replacement
- ☐ Patio door installation
- ☐ New door opening
- ☐ Multiple doors

Number of Doors: _____

Budget: \$_____

Timeline: Start date: _____ | Completion date: _____

Door Specifications

Door Type: _____

Material: _____

Size: Width: _____ | Height: _____

Style/Design: _____

Color/Finish: _____

Glass Type (if applicable): _____

Hardware Selections

Handleset/Knob Style: _____

Finish: _____

Lock Type: _____

Additional Features:

- ☐ Smart lock
- ☐ Deadbolt
- ☐ Peephole
- ☐ Kick plate
- ☐ Door closer

Installation Notes

Existing Frame Condition:

- ☐ Good (can reuse)
- ☐ Needs repair
- ☐ Needs replacement

Special Requirements:

- ☐ Weatherstripping
 - ☐ Threshold replacement
 - ☐ Trim/casing work
 - ☐ Painting/staining
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Pro Tips from Hero Handyman Pro

Invest in Your Entry Door: Your front door is the first impression of your home. A quality entry door improves curb appeal, security, and energy efficiency—often returning 70-90% of its cost at resale.

Don' t Forget Weatherstripping: Even the best door won' t perform well without proper weatherstripping. This simple addition prevents drafts, reduces energy costs, and keeps out moisture and pests.

Match Hardware Finishes: For a cohesive look, use the same hardware finish throughout your home (or at least on the same floor). This small detail makes a big difference in overall design.

Measure Twice, Order Once: Door returns are expensive and time-consuming. Always double-check measurements before ordering, especially for pre-hung doors.

Consider Future Needs: If you plan to age in place, choose lever-style handles (easier to operate) and ensure doorways are at least 32" wide for wheelchair accessibility.

Ready to Upgrade Your Doors?

Hero Handyman Pro specializes in door installation and replacement throughout St. Louis and Metro East. From entry doors to interior upgrades, we ensure proper fit, smooth operation, and lasting quality.

Call us today for a free consultation: 800-741-6056

Visit: herohandymanpro.com

This guide is provided as an educational resource by Hero Handyman Pro. Actual costs, requirements, and recommendations may vary based on your specific project and local building codes.